

Impact of employee well-being on performance in the context of crisis-induced remote work: role of boundary control and professional isolation

Boundary
control and
professional
isolation

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Abstract

Purpose – COVID-19 forced employees to work remotely. Since this shift from physical to remote working was sudden and unprecedented, the authors aimed to examine the impact of employee well-being on performance in the context of remote work. Further, the authors explored how feelings of professional isolation and employees' control over their personal and professional boundaries (i.e. boundary control) moderated the well-being and performance link. The authors invoke the equity theory and boundary theory to augment their hypotheses.

Design/methodology/approach – With 218 full-time employees representing large information technology organisations in India, the authors tested the hypothesised relationships using regression and double moderation in the PROCESS macro.

Findings – Results indicate that well-being has a significant positive impact on employee performance as they worked remotely. Further, the authors found that professional isolation and boundary control moderated the link between well-being and performance such that when boundary control is high and professional isolation is low, the aforementioned relationship strengthened and vice versa.

Research limitations/implications – The authors extend the boundary theory as the crisis-induced remote work highlighted the employees' need for deploying alternating boundary management styles to balance their personal and professional lives.

Practical implications – Organisations must develop flexible work policies to facilitate remote work and managers must efficiently craft the overall management of professional isolation and employees' boundaries to boost their well-being and performance.

Originality/value – The authors not only examine the impact of employee well-being on performance in the context of remote work but also, in a first, examine the role of boundary control and professional isolation in this relationship.

Keywords Remote work, Employee well-being, Performance, Boundary control, Professional isolation, India

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

Though remote work has existed in organisational policy and practice for the last few decades, its actual implementation was witnessed during the COVID-19 pandemic. Before the pandemic, few employees availed the opportunity to work remotely, however, the COVID-19 crisis made remote work a forced reality for most employees around the world. The pandemic led to an unforeseen acceleration of the implementation of remote working across the globe (Blahopoulou *et al.*, 2022). Since organisations could not function physically, they encouraged (and later forced) their employees to telework for business continuity. Though the pandemic redefined how people and organisations function across industries, the unprecedented shift from physical to virtual work environment was most evident in the technology-driven service industries. As most employees worked remotely (either from home or other locations), organisations realised that the pandemic had created the most significant organisational design shock of our lifetimes (Hoff, 2021).



Remote work, also known as telework, work from anywhere, or e-work, is an alternate work arrangement. Advances in Information and Communication Technology (ICT) have played a pivotal role in facilitating remote work, especially during the pandemic (Ollo-López *et al.*, 2021). Scholars concur that there are two main characteristics of remote work arrangements: employees performing their jobs while being away from the traditional office workspace and they use ICT to work (Baruch, 2000; Gajendran and Harrison, 2007). Thus, in this study, we refer to *remote work as organisational work performed outside of the organisational confines of space and time facilitated by ICT* (Olson, 1983). While conventional remote work has been in practice for a few decades, the present crisis-induced remote work is different (Blahopoulou *et al.*, 2022; Jaiswal *et al.*, 2022). Conventional remote work was a voluntary option to provide flexibility to those employees who wanted to work from outside the office space. However, crisis-induced remote work is a sudden and non-voluntary work arrangement to respond to the emergency caused by the pandemic. In the present case, employees were neither mentally nor physically prepared for such a massive shift from a traditional office work environment to outside-the-office alternate workspaces. Thus, we believe that crisis-induced remote work would have a decisive impact on employees including their well-being and performance.

During the initial phase of this crisis-induced remote work, employees faced several challenges such as poor Internet connectivity, lack of adequate hardware and software, lack of a designated workspace, childcare, homeschooling, elderly care, and performing household chores (due to the lack of domestic help during the pandemic). During this phase, the COVID-19 pandemic was also at its peak, hence, people had a lot of stress and anxiety related to health and safety from the deadly coronavirus. On the professional front, employees were asked to work remotely without adequate planning and training which led to sustained uncertainty (Zhang-Zhang *et al.*, 2022). Employees were not only finding it difficult to manage their work and family demands but also, felt a sense of isolation due to reduced face-to-face interaction with other organisational members. In addition, employees were unable to focus on their work due to interruptions such as helping the child with their lesson or purchasing items to fulfil daily/medical needs. While these indicate non-work interruptions, they were significant for employees to address because families were isolated and had to be self-reliant during the pandemic. Thus, the boundaries between work and family blurred (Adisa *et al.*, 2022). These overwhelming changes in an individual's life on both personal and professional fronts are deemed to have a significant impact on employee well-being and performance.

Indeed, employee well-being became the top-most priority for most organisations during the initial phase of the pandemic (Collings *et al.*, 2021; Tuzovic and Kabadayi, 2021). Organisations tied up with counselling experts and set up helplines to keep a constant check on the well-being of their employees. While well-being was at the forefront for most organisations, employee performance was also a matter of key concern for most employers because performance is ultimately the engine for an organisation's growth and success. Besides increased stress, inadequate infrastructure, and feelings of lack of belongingness, there are other downsides of remote work such as lack of communication, increased need for coordination, unrealistic performance expectations, weakened leader-member relationship, and difficulty in establishing trust with organisational members (Narayanamurthy and Tortorella, 2021; Varma *et al.*, 2022). Studies conducted during the initial phase of the pandemic indicated either a negative impact on performance or the same level of performance at the cost of employee burnout (Graves and Karabayeva, 2020; Maurer, 2020; Narayanamurthy and Tortorella, 2021; Shockley *et al.*, 2021).

The initial phase of remote work forced by the pandemic was more like an experimental phase for both the employees and the employers (Gifford, 2022). Employees' work and family permeated their personal and professional boundaries. Employees had no choice but to manage the blurring of boundaries. However, as employees gradually settled into their new

remote work pattern, boundary violation emerged as their key pain point (Jaiswal *et al.*, 2022; Varma *et al.*, 2022). Work spillover into the personal life of employees was predominant such that employees perceived that they were expected by their managers to be available for work virtually throughout the day (24X7) and over non-workdays. Not surprisingly, this was a technostress caused by the overuse (and misuse) of ICT (Camacho and Barrios, 2022; Rodriguez and Choudrie, 2021; Spagnoli *et al.*, 2020; Tarafdar *et al.*, 2015; Taser *et al.*, 2022). Thus, employees struggled to manage their boundaries and wished to gain boundary control. Further, employees felt professionally isolated due to the lack of face-to-face interaction and informal chats (Sahoo *et al.*, 2022). Despite virtual connect, there was a sudden void felt by employees with regard to informal mentoring, casual discussions for problem-solving, and the occasional exchange of pleasantries that contributed to employee's sense of belongingness with the organisation (Sutarto *et al.*, 2022; Taser *et al.*, 2022). Hence, employees felt out of the loop and most importantly felt that they were missing out on professional opportunities for growth.

Given the above discussion on the potential impact of employee well-being on performance during remote work and the role of boundary control and professional isolation in the employee well-being and performance relationship, we set the following three objectives for our present study: (1) To examine the relationship between employee well-being and performance in the context of remote work (2) To investigate the moderating role of boundary control in the well-being–performance relationship, (3) To investigate the moderating role of professional isolation in the well-being–performance relationship.

The present study has two key contributions. First, we make a novel theoretical contribution to the emerging literature on remote work that was forced on employees at an unprecedented scale due to the pandemic. While there is sufficient literature on the link between well-being and performance, our study provides a more nuanced understanding of this relationship in the context of remote work. Employee well-being and performance are both critical for individuals and organisations alike. We invoke the equity theory and understand the well-being and performance link with the contextual lens of remote work. Second, to the best of the authors' knowledge, this is the first study to examine the moderating role of boundary control and professional isolation in the well-being–performance relationship. The impact of well-being on performance is ambiguous and seems far from being straightforward due to a lack of sufficient evidence in the context of crisis-induced remote work (Blahopoulou *et al.*, 2022). Thus, we extend the boundary theory in the context of crisis-induced remote work and highlight the employees' need to control the boundaries between their personal and professional lives so that the impact of their well-being on performance strengthens. We also examine the role of professional isolation in the well-being and performance link.

The remaining paper is structured as follows. In the following sections, we briefly present the theoretical underpinnings for our proposed hypotheses, describe the method deployed for the study, and highlight the key study findings. We then discuss the theoretical and practical implications of our findings and highlight future directions for more research in this nascent phenomenon of crisis-induced remote work.

Theory and hypotheses

Employee well-being and performance

An individual's well-being is a holistic integration of various aspects, such as social, psychological, physical, emotional, and workplace well-being. Since an employee spends a considerable amount of their time at the workplace, their well-being at work contributes immensely to their overall well-being. We operationalise employee well-being as *well-being drawn from employees' work and their work environment* (Jaiswal and Dyaram, 2019). Past

research has found that employee well-being is not only important for individuals but also for organisations (Haile, 2012; Jaiswal and Dyaram, 2019; Wilks and Neto, 2013). Employees who reported higher levels of well-being were found to be high on engagement, demonstrated higher levels of creativity, reported fewer health issues, stayed longer with the organisation, were more productive, and performed better as compared to those employees who reported low levels of well-being (Anderson *et al.*, 2015; Khoreva and Wechtler, 2018; Lyubomirsky *et al.*, 2005; Zhang *et al.*, 2020). These improved individual outcomes have a direct impact on the organisational bottom line, thus making it imperative for organisations to keep employee well-being at the core of their business (Kowalski and Loretto, 2017).

Individual performance or employee actions that are relevant for achieving organisational goals are a critical outcome for individuals and organisations alike. The primary focus of performance pivots around the task. Task performance is operationally defined as *the proficiency with which individuals perform the core substantive or technical tasks central to their job* (Koopmans *et al.*, 2013). Task performance involves employee behaviours that are directly related to producing goods or services for the organisation's core processes (Van Scotter *et al.*, 2000). When employees use their skills and knowledge to accomplish a task, they engage in task performance (Koopmans *et al.*, 2014). Behaviours that describe the task performance include the quantity and quality of work, skills, and knowledge required for the task.

Past research has found that employee well-being positively impacts performance (Anderson *et al.*, 2015; Khoreva and Wechtler, 2018; Lyubomirsky *et al.*, 2005; Zhang *et al.*, 2020). We invoke Adams's (1963) *equity theory* which proposes that people invest in certain relationships and receive benefits from that relationship. Equity is experienced when the investments are equal to the benefits received whereas inequity results when one invests more in a relationship but receives less and vice versa. At the workplace, employees invest their personal resources such as time, effort, knowledge, and skills, to receive compensation, rewards, and respect. Satisfied and happy employees perceive equity and thus, feel obliged to their employer. They reciprocate by being more productive, investing more personal resources in the organisation, and performing better in terms of quality and quantity.

While there was a growing impetus for employee well-being in the past few decades, the COVID-19 pandemic brought well-being to the forefront. To survive in turbulent times, organisations across industries forced employees to work from home or a remote location as much as possible. Employees underwent a lot of stress due to various factors that reduced their well-being. First, most employees were not equipped to work from home. They lacked the necessary physical infrastructure such as ergonomically designed furniture for long working hours or a quiet place in their home to work. In addition, they had inadequate technology-related infrastructure, such as a laptop or broadband connection that could facilitate their work (Jaiswal *et al.*, 2022). Second, in addition to their office work, people had to perform all the household work themselves due to a lack of domestic help during the pandemic. The situation was further complicated by individuals taking care of their children's homeschooling as well as elderly care (Galanti *et al.*, 2021). Third, people were scared about the disease COVID-19 itself. With the pandemic spreading uncontrollably and causing deaths, news of companies shutting down, and employees losing their jobs across the globe, there was heightened anxiety and stress among people with regard to their lives and livelihoods (Blahopoulou *et al.*, 2022). Fourth, more specifically related to organisations, people reported feelings of uncertainty, social and professional isolation (Golden *et al.*, 2008; Sahoo *et al.*, 2022; Zhang-Zhang *et al.*, 2022). They felt a reduced sense of belongingness with their team and organisation, communication levels dropped while the need for coordination increased (Wang *et al.*, 2021). Casual and non-verbal communication at the workplace is extremely important for smooth work functioning. This mode of communication was lost during remote work (Sutarto *et al.*, 2022; Taser *et al.*, 2022). In this connection, we believe that employee well-being plummeted as they worked remotely.

With regards to performance, several researchers (Devonish and Greenidge, 2010; Koopmans *et al.*, 2013; Van Scotter *et al.*, 2000) have broadened the scope of individual performance to task performance and contextual performance (i.e. behavioural patterns that support the psychological and social context in which task activities are performed), however, we scope our study to task performance. This is because while working remotely during the COVID-19 pandemic, the employees were unable to focus on contextual aspects of work such as helping others to complete their tasks or suggesting ways to improve organisational processes. As employees at all levels in the organisation were anxious, dealing with the uncertainty related to the pandemic, and deploying coping mechanisms to overcome the pressures of day-to-day functioning, they were barely able to deliver their routine task-related outcomes (Alexander *et al.*, 2021; Blahopoulou *et al.*, 2022).

In the context of remote work during COVID-19, Wang *et al.* (2021) found that employee well-being and performance were both positive when individuals had higher levels of job autonomy. Since people with job autonomy could balance their work and personal life, they experienced well-being and could perform better than those employees who were low on well-being. They also demonstrated that the role of social support became much more evident during the pandemic. When employees felt supported by their managers and peers, it led to higher employee well-being, thereby, driving their performance. Likewise, other recent studies have found that social support in the form of empathy and compassion particularly from the immediate supervisor helped enhance employee well-being and performance (Juchnowicz and Kinowska, 2021; Tuzovic and Kabadayi, 2021). Thus, we posit that:

- H1. As employees work remotely, their well-being will have a positive impact on their task performance.

Boundary control and professional isolation as moderators in the employee well-being and performance link

The increasing use of information and communication technologies (ICT) made it possible for individuals to stay connected with other organisational members 24X7. Reliance on ICT became necessary due to the increasingly global and geographically dispersed operations of an organisation. Further, work structures have also undergone a change with regard to flexible work arrangements such as flexitime and remote work. While the use of ICT is a boon for smooth business functioning, it has captured people in perpetual work as ICT has encroached on the work-family boundaries, thus leading to the blurring of lines between an individual's personal and professional lives (Varma *et al.*, 2022). We thus invoke the *boundary theory* (Nippert-Eng, 1996) which highlights that people draw boundaries between their personal and professional lives to maintain a balance. Employees use various approaches to demarcate work-life boundaries so that they can attend to work and family roles adequately. These approaches include work-family segmentation or integration. Boundary theory suggests that people have diverse levels of tolerance with regard to their boundaries and how they manage these boundaries depends on their individual choice for boundary management (Jaiswal *et al.*, 2022). People differ in the ways they control, segregate, and consolidate boundaries while engaging in work and non-work roles (Kossek *et al.*, 2012).

Boundary control becomes more pronounced when employees worked remotely during the COVID-19 pandemic as there was immense scope for overlapping personal and professional activities. Inadvertent boundary violations occurred as employees were finding it difficult to focus on work during the designated work hours due to personal demands that required immediate attention (for example, attending to the doorbell to take groceries or pacifying a wailing child) or focussing on personal requirements during off-work hours due to sudden requests from manager or colleagues for troubleshooting. Boundary control is the degree to which individuals perceive that they possess the ability to contract or expand a

boundary (Clark, 2000). Boundary control is operationally defined as *psychological interpretations of perceived control over one’s boundary environment* (Kossek et al., 2012).

We propose boundary control as a moderator in the relationship between employee well-being and performance. Figure 1 summarises the hypothesised relationships. Kossek and Lautsch (2012) found that when individuals perceived low boundary control, they experienced more negative outcomes such as work-family conflict. They were stressed as the demands of the context were greater than their ability to control. Since boundary crossings happened very often, overall, individuals had negative feelings related to work-family balance, well-being, and performance (De Gieter et al., 2022). On the contrary, individuals who perceived high boundary control believed that they controlled the timing, frequency, and direction of boundary crossings to cater to the work-family role demands. In a study of teleworkers, Kossek et al. (2006) found that when individuals felt they were in control of their work and work characteristics, they were able to integrate work-family boundaries. In a recent study, De Gieter et al. (2022) found that perceived work-nonwork boundary management resulted in lower levels of work-family conflict as employees were able to balance both roles as per their personal preference, consequently improving their performance. In this connection, we believe that when individuals perceive high levels of boundary control, employee well-being will positively impact their performance because they will feel in charge of the task. When individuals control their boundaries, they are empowered to use their judgement to take the decisions of how, when, and where the tasks are to be performed in the remote work environment.

Despite technology connecting people inevitably, employees sometimes feel disconnected. Employees have an inherent feeling to be socially connected with others at the workplace, however, they feel professionally isolated when they believe that they lack adequate connection with other organisational members. “Professional isolation is a state of mind or belief that one is out of touch with others in the workplace” (Golden et al., 2008, p. 1412). Feelings of isolation make teleworking employees believe that they are “out-of-sight” and hence, “out-of-mind” of the critical networks and decision-makers in the organisation (Mulki and Jaramillo, 2011). Employees who work remotely believe that since they are out of sight, they do not have an equal level of career support, opportunities, interpersonal networking, informal learning, and mentoring, as compared to employees who are insight of the managers (Cooper and Kurland, 2002). Thus, feelings of professional isolation among remote working employees may lead to a perception of missed or fewer opportunities for key projects and promotions.

Feelings of professional isolation exacerbate as teleworking employees may lack “social barometers” to benchmark themselves and their work behaviours with others in the organisation. Lack of social benchmarks may lead to feelings such as a lack of competencies, reduced self-efficacy, and lack of confidence in their abilities or job knowledge. Further, professional isolation can lead to a reduced sense of belongingness, increased frustration, dissatisfaction, and burnout among employees (Golden et al., 2008). These feelings can

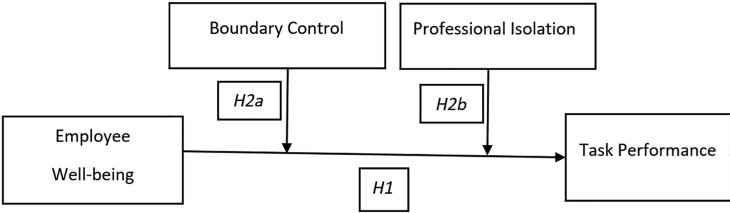


Figure 1.
Summary of
hypothesised
relationships

Source(s): Author’s own creation

thereby negatively impact the relationship between their well-being and performance. In a recent study conducted during the COVID-19 pandemic, Galanti *et al.* (2021) found evidence that professional isolation negatively impacted employee performance. In this connection, we propose that the relationship between well-being and performance will weaken if employees feel professionally isolated while teleworking. Thus, we posit that:

- H2a.* Boundary control will moderate the relationship between employee well-being and task performance such that when boundary control is high the relationship between well-being and performance will improve.
- H2b.* Professional isolation will moderate the relationship between employee well-being and task performance such that when feelings of isolation are high the relationship between well-being and performance will deteriorate.

Method

Study context

The present study is conducted in the Indian Information Technology and IT-enabled service (IT/ITeS) sectors. The Indian IT industry contributed 9% to India's economic growth in 2021 and accounted for 51% of services exports (Phadnis, 2022). This industry generated a revenue of more than US\$200 billion and employed five million professionals (including 1.8 million women), thus, becoming the highest employment provider in the private sector in India (NASSCOM, 2022) [1]. India has gained immense global visibility and prominence with regard to its intellectual capital and demographic dividend with several IT global firms setting up their major hubs and innovation centres in India. Due to its core competencies and strengths, the industry has attracted significant investments from major countries and global companies (IBEF, 2022). Further, the Indian government's thrust on Digital India yielded a 67.13% jump in the annual budget allocation for the sector for the fiscal year 2022–23 (Ghosh, 2022).

The Indian IT industry provided an ideal setting for the present study. This is because while the COVID-19 pandemic impacted most industries, the IT industry was least impacted due to the nature of its operations. Digital technologies helped people and businesses to overcome the worsening situation due to the COVID-19 pandemic. No sooner than the pandemic and closure of offices were announced, the majority of the IT sector was able to switch to remote work swiftly and smoothly. Due to the feasibility of operating remotely, even in the post-pandemic recovery phase, many IT organisations have given their employees the flexibility to work either fully remote or a few days every week. Thus, the present study aimed to analyse the impact of employee well-being on performance as employees worked remotely.

Sample and procedure

The key variables of the present study, i.e. employee well-being, performance, boundary control, and professional isolation, are well-established constructs in the literature. However, we chose quantitative methodology for this study to investigate how these variables varied in the context of the COVID-19 pandemic as reported by the employees. Data for the present study were collected from employees with more than 5 years of work experience. We set this inclusion criterion for the study because employees with more than five years of experience would have an adequate amount of exposure to work from the office (pre-COVID) and work remotely (during and post-COVID). Hence, we adopted the non-probability approach of purposive sampling for the present study. A questionnaire for data collection was created using Google survey forms. Before sharing the survey link, we contacted the potential respondents and

briefed them about the purpose of the research study. The link was shared with those employees who gave their consent to participate in the survey-based study. Participants were assured of the confidentiality and anonymity of their responses. We reached out to 300 prospective employees out of which 218 returned the duly filled questionnaire yielding a response rate of 72.6%. [Table 1](#) demonstrates the distribution of samples.

Measures

The survey questionnaire was designed into two sections. Through section one, we sought demographic information from the participants including gender, age, marital status, number of years of work experience, the preferred mode of work, and number of working hours. In section two, we collected the responses for the key study variables, i.e. employee well-being, performance, boundary control, and professional isolation. All the scales used for the study were well-established, reliable, and validated scales. Below are the details of the scales used for the present study:

Employee well-being: Well-being was measured using the WHO-5 well-being index ([Blahopoulou et al., 2022](#)). The 5-point rating scale ranged from all of the time to some of the time. Sample item includes, “I have felt cheerful and in good spirits.”

Employee task performance: Performance was measured using the task performance sub-scale from the Individual Work Performance Questionnaire ([Koopmans et al., 2013](#)) Task performance scale has five items measured on a five-point rating scale from Sometimes to Always. Sample item includes, “I managed to plan my work so that it was done on time.”

Boundary control: Boundary control was assessed using a three-item sub-scale from Kossek and colleagues’ Work-life indicator ([2012](#)) measure. The rating scale was from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree). Sample item includes, “I control whether I combine my work and personal life activities throughout the day.”

Professional isolation: Professional isolation was measured using a seven-item scale developed by [Golden et al. \(2008\)](#). The rating scale was from 1 (rarely) to 5 (most of the time). Sample item includes, “I feel left out on activities and meetings that could enhance my career.”

Characteristics	Category	% (n = 218)
Age	21–30	29
	31–40	59
	41–50	10
	50+	2
Gender	Female	44
	Male	56
Marital status	Married	75
	Other	1
	Single	24
Mode of work	Hybrid mode	62
	Remote work	27
	Work from office	11
Working hours per day	8–12 Hours	81
	Less than 8 h	16
	More than 8 h	3
Work experience	5–10	54
	11–15	31
	16–20	8
	Above 21	7

Table 1.
Sample characteristics **Source(s):** Authors’ own creation

Control variables: Two variables were chosen as controls in our study including the preferred mode of work and number of working hours as these variables may influence our results. The preferred mode of work was coded as hybrid mode (1), work from home only (2), and work from office only (3). The number of working hours was coded as less than 8 h (1), 8–12 h (2), and more than 12 h (3).

Appendix highlights all the items for the measures used in the study.

Common method bias: Self-report measures such as those used in the present study may lead to common method bias (CMB). Hence, we used procedural remedies recommended to contain the possibility of CMB, such as the consent letter assuring the respondents of anonymity and confidentiality (Podsakoff *et al.*, 2012). Further, we used Harman's single-factor method to detect CMB. We found that the single factor accounted for 30.93% of the variance among the measures. Since this value is below the suggested threshold of 50% (Podsakoff *et al.*, 2012), it indicates that the data is free from possible social desirability bias or shared variance among the measured variables.

Results

We analysed how well-being impacts the performance of employees while working remotely through linear regression and tested for the moderation effects of boundary control on the relationship between well-being and performance. We found support for our hypotheses. We found employee well-being to significantly predict performance (H1) and both the moderators, i.e. boundary control and professional isolation were found to significantly interact with employee well-being to influence performance, thus, supporting H2a and H2b. We also found that the link between well-being and performance was stronger when boundary control was high and professional isolation was low, and vice versa. Mean, standard deviation, correlation among the study variables, and Cronbach's alpha for scale reliability are summarised in Table 2.

From Tables 2, it is observed that the key study variables employee well-being, performance, boundary control, and professional isolation, have a significant correlation with each other. We checked for the assumptions of normality through normal probability plotting and we also tested for similar variances by plotting the residuals on the fitted values. Cronbach's alpha for all the variables is above 0.88, thus, establishing the reliabilities of all the scales used for the study.

Regression results

Linear regression results indicated that employee well-being ($\beta = 0.276$, $t = 4.09$, $p = 0.000$) significantly predicts their performance. Thus, we found support for hypothesis 1. The F-statistic of 6.38 ($p = 0.000$, $df = 3, 214$) shows that the overall model is significant.

Variables	Mean	Standard deviation	Cronbach's alpha	EWB	TP	BC	PI
Employee Well-being	3.55	0.93	0.91	1			
Task performance	3.22	1.12	0.93	0.28**	1		
Boundary Control	3.42	0.99	0.91	0.24**	0.26**	1	
Professional isolation	2.26	0.86	0.88	-0.30**	-0.16*	-0.04	1

Note(s): $n = 218$, ** $p < 0.01$

Source(s): Authors' own creation

Table 2.
Means, standard deviations, Cronbach's alpha and correlations among variables

Testing for double moderation effects

Figure 2 shows the interaction effects of boundary control in the relationship between employee well-being and task performance. Interaction effects in our study were tested using Model 2 in SPSS PROCESS macro v4.0 (Hayes, 2013). The main effects of EWB, PI, and BC ($F(5, 212) = 9.61, p = 0.000$) accounted for 16.03% of the variance in performance, and we found support for hypotheses 2a and 2b. Boundary control significantly impacted performance (coeff = 0.23, $p = 0.003$) and a significant interaction between EWB and BC on performance was evident (coeff = 0.21, $p = 0.003$). While professional isolation significantly impacted performance (coeff = $-0.17, p = 0.043$), the interaction between EWB and PI was not significant. However, the highest-order interaction among EWB, BC, and PI was significant ($p = 0.010$). The interaction between EWB, BC, and PI accounted for an additional 3.56% variance ($p = 0.010$) beyond the main effects. Figure 2 illustrates the regression lines for the effect of well-being on performance across various levels of the two moderators. The continuous line in the graph represents low BC whereas the top dotted line represents high BC. The upper, middle, and lower parts of the graph represent conditions of low, average, and high PI, respectively. The key finding is that the impact of EWB on performance is highest when BC is high and PI is low (4.05 – top most dotted line in the upper part of the graph) while the impact of EWB on performance is lowest when BC is low and PI is high (2.85 – bottom most continuous line in the lower part of the graph).

Discussion

We set out to examine the impact of employee well-being on task performance in the context of remote work and investigate how boundary control and professional isolation moderated the relationship between well-being and performance.

Past research has found a positive impact of employee well-being on their performance (Achor, 2012; Lyubomirsky *et al.*, 2005; Khoreva and Wechtler, 2018; Kowalski and Loretto,

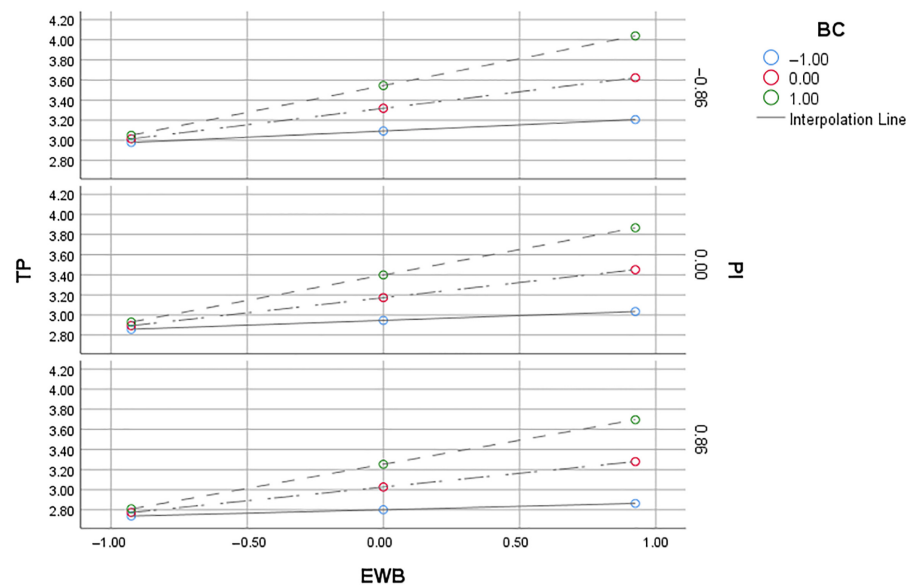


Figure 2.
Interaction plot

Source(s): Author's own creation

2017; Lyubomirsky *et al.*, 2005). However, during the pandemic, employee well-being became a major source of concern for most employers and was given utmost importance. As COVID-19 forced organisations to physically shut down, organisations forced their employees to work remotely. Employees underwent a lot of stress due to the fear of the disease itself, the blurring of personal and professional boundaries, and balancing work and family demands (Adisa *et al.*, 2022). We proposed that employee well-being will have a positive impact on their performance, and we found support for our hypothesis. In line with the equity theory, we found that when employees invest their personal resources in an organisation and receive similar reciprocation from the employers, they perceive equity and report a sense of well-being. This goes in tandem with their performance and positively impacts their development as well as the organisational growth.

Managers need to skilfully navigate the people-profit paradox while employees work remotely. We refer to the mutuality lens in this regard (Boxall, 2013). The mutuality lens helps to understand how managers can align the employees' core capabilities toward sustainable performance. The key tenet of this approach is that high-quality employment relationships lead to sustainable employee performance. When employees have good relationships with their colleagues and manager, they experience a sense of well-being related to their job. Thus, managers must invest in enhancing the well-being of their employees such that performance is an inevitable outcome.

Despite the stress employees faced while working remotely, most employees in the study sample reported moderate levels of well-being because of the social support they received from their managers and peers virtually. Studies have highlighted that managers have taken good care of their employees' well-being during the pandemic (Collings *et al.*, 2021; Tuzovic and Kabadayi, 2021). When employees receive adequate support from other organisational members, they experience well-being. Our findings concur with the literature on employee well-being and performance (Anderson *et al.*, 2015; Khoreva and Wechtler, 2018; Lyubomirsky *et al.*, 2005) that when employees experience well-being, they tend to perform better. In line with the equity theory, when employees receive care, consideration, and compassion, they reciprocate by investing a greater amount of their personal resources to perform better. While we invoke the recent work of Zhang *et al.* (2020) wherein the authors examined the performance–well-being link, since our study findings are more nuanced as the study was conducted during the context of crisis. Further, we explored the well-being–performance link more intricately by examining the role of contextual factors (i.e. boundary control and professional isolation) that significantly interplay in the relationship between employee well-being and their performance.

We also found support for hypotheses 2a and 2b. Boundary control and professional isolation significantly moderated the relationship between employee well-being and performance. Individuals who were able to control their personal and professional boundaries and felt less isolated reported a stronger impact of their well-being on performance. In line with past scholarly work (De Gieter *et al.*, 2022; Kossek *et al.*, 2006, 2012), we found that individuals who perceived they had high control over their boundaries were able to control the timing, frequency, and direction of boundary crossings. This helped them to address their work-family role demands well causing low work-family conflict. When individuals felt involved in the organisational activities, felt connected to their peers emotionally, and did not miss face-to-face contact or informal communication, they reported having low feelings of professional isolation. Thus, these aspects of boundary control and professional isolation strengthened the impact of well-being on their task performance.

However, when individuals felt that they had low boundary control and high professional isolation, the impact of well-being on performance deteriorated. As employees worked from home, their personal and professional lives overlapped (Jaiswal *et al.*, 2022; Varma *et al.*, 2022). Though low boundary control leads to constant navigation between work and family

demands, it did not impact the relationship between well-being and performance because employees got used to the lack of control over boundaries. They had come to terms with the new situation of working virtually in the physical spaces of their homes such that they felt that controlling boundaries with regards to the timing, frequency, and direction of boundary crossing, was beyond their control. Further, they felt out-of-the-loop professionally, missed informal interactions with colleagues, felt that they lost opportunities to be mentored or to advance in their careers due to remote work, they reported high levels of professional isolation. These findings were in line with the recent scholarly works ([Galanti et al., 2021](#); [Sahoo et al., 2022](#); [Sutarto et al., 2022](#); [Taser et al., 2022](#)). Thus, feelings of being cut off from the organisational network and low control over work-life boundaries worsened the impact of well-being on performance.

Our findings extend the present understanding of boundary theory. Before the pandemic, if organisational policy permitted remote work, there was a mutual understanding between the employer and employee. The terms and conditions of service were such that the employee had the flexibility to work at his/her pace and space. Employees were provided adequate training to work remotely and had adequate infrastructure (physical and technology-related) at the remote location to deliver the expected task outcomes. When employees worked remotely, it was their choice. They had the right mindset to work remotely, and it allowed them to manage their work and family demands well. Thus, employees were able to manage their work-family boundaries and control the boundaries to a large extent. However, the current phenomenon of remote work was involuntary. Employees were forced to work from home when they neither had any training or preparation nor the right infrastructure. In addition, there was the stress of the pandemic and the responsibility of household chores (including childcare and homeschooling). Employees also did not have the mindset of working remotely because so far, they had a clear distinction between work and home. These factors led to inevitable boundary violations as demands of both work and family were high during the pandemic. It was highly likely that the employees felt that the situation was beyond their control, and they could not manage or control the boundary permeabilities. Thus, the crisis-induced remote work phenomenon brought out some of these newer facets of the boundary theory. While most scholarly work on boundary theory promotes either segmentation or integration as an individual's predominant boundary management style, [Kossek and Lautsch \(2012, p. 154\)](#) highlighted that depending upon the situation, people may have to alternate their focus on work, family, or both and may enact different patterns of boundary management. They called this an "alternating boundary management style." The crisis-induced remote work brought the alternating boundary management style to the forefront; thus, our study addressed the call for more research by [Kossek and Lautsch \(2012\)](#).

Practical implications

During the pandemic, remote work was involuntary for employees. Since organisations forced their employees to work remotely, managers had a major role to play in controlling the employees' work-life relationships. Often, work-related activities invaded the employees' personal boundaries. While individuals are responsible for their boundary management, managers must better craft the overall management of personal-professional boundaries. This is not only beneficial for the individuals in the long term but also for organisational sustainability. Since managers are responsible for the alignment between employee and organisational goals, a prudent boundary management approach will generate greater returns for all stakeholders ([Collings et al., 2021](#)).

Despite boundary violations, some employees felt professionally isolated leading to a negative impact on the well-being and performance link. This is detrimental to organisations; thus, organisations should establish more meaningful communication networks that

engender employee inclusion and belongingness. Communication models must not only focus on the quantity of communication but also the quality of communication. Too frequent communication makes it difficult for employees to discern the importance of various messages. Rather, managerial communication that empathises with remote working employees and helps them to overcome any feelings of isolation is quintessential to enhancing employee well-being and performance.

Since employees and managers are bound by organisational policies, the study findings have implications for policymakers as well. Organisations need to develop flexible work policies to facilitate remote work while ensuring employee well-being. While the key outcome for the organisation is performance, managers must provide adequate support to employees working remotely. Support can be in the form of providing access to resources needed by the remote working employee or empathy and compassion from the leader that would help the employee maintain good mental health and happiness (Tuzovic and Kabadayi, 2021). Increasing job autonomy as people work remotely will also facilitate employee well-being as it will provide the employee the opportunity to balance personal and professional demands (Meyer *et al.*, 2021). Thus, organisational policies must be framed in such a manner that managers can provide sufficient social support and autonomy to their employees toward maintaining their well-being as well as their performance.

Limitations and future directions

While the study contributes to the growing literature on remote work, we highlight some limitations and directions for future research. First, the small sample size and the cross-sectional nature of the study limit our confidence to be conclusive about the findings. However, future research can retest the study hypotheses in a longitudinal research design with a larger sample size. Our findings are based on Indian respondents; hence, the results cannot be generalised to other cultural contexts. Thus, future researchers can conduct the study in other countries to make the findings generalisable.

Second, we have included boundary control and professional isolation as moderators in the well-being and performance link. However, other variables that may impact this relationship in the context of remote work may also be included. For instance, the role of communication is often cited as critical for remote workers' performance (Shockley *et al.*, 2021). This is because remote workers should be able to communicate with other organisational members through virtual and social means such as email, phone, messaging, and video conferencing. It is important that when the communication is not face-to-face, the quality and quantity of communication are good. Miscommunication will hamper both employee well-being and performance.

Third, crisis-induced remote work was an unplanned yet major experiment for most organisations. While many organisations are insisting that their employees return to work from office else, they may run the risk of being fired, there may be some employees who would want to continue working remotely full-time (Dirchi, 2022). Future research can identify the types of employees who prefer work from the office only, hybrid work, or remote only, and deliberate on the implications of these mixed work modalities on diversity and inclusion. How can organisations ensure that certain groups of employees are not unduly disadvantaged in the long term due to their preferred mode of work? These are some of the directions for future research with regard to well-being and performance in the context of remote work.

Conclusion

Due to the COVID-19 pandemic, organisations worldwide demanded their employees to work remotely facilitated by information and communication technology. The pandemic and changed work modalities impacted the well-being of people, yet they had to continue their

work to sustain their livelihood. While the well-being of employees was the top concern of most organisations, organisations were also worried about employee performance. We found that employees who reported well-being also report superior performance. Further, when employees perceived that they were in control of their work-family boundaries and were professionally less isolated, their well-being had a stronger impact on their performance. The study has key implications for managers and organisational policymakers to create a conducive remote work environment that will not only enhance employee well-being but also drive sustainable performance.

Note

1. National Association of Software and Services Companies (NASSCOM) is the agency responsible for IT and items sector in India.

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(The Appendix follows overleaf)

Table A1.
Measures used in
the study

Appendix

Items

- WHO-5 well-being scale* (Blahopoulou *et al.*, 2022)
I have felt cheerful and in good spirits
I have felt calm and relaxed
I have felt active and vigorous
I woke up feeling fresh and rested
My daily life has been filled with things that interest me
Task performance scale (Koopman *et al.*, 2013)
I managed to plan my work so that it was done on time
My planning was optimal
I was able to separate main issues from side issues at work
I was able to perform my work well with minimal time and effort
I kept in mind the results that I had to achieve in my work
Boundary control (Kossek *et al.*, 2012)
I control whether I am able to keep my work and personal life separate
I control whether I have clear boundaries between my work and personal life
I control whether I combine my work and personal life activities throughout the day
Professional isolation (Golden *et al.*, 2008)
I feel left out on activities and meetings that could enhance my career
I miss out on opportunities to be mentored
I feel out of the loop
I miss face-to-face contact with co-workers
I feel isolated
I miss the emotional support of co-workers
I miss informal interaction with others
Source(s): Citations given for each measure

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